
MiSTer Monitor

Setup Guide

v2.11.0

RETROACHIEVEMENTS

PROGRESS 23/40

57%



[H]	Perfect Run	25p
[*]	First Blood	10p
[]	Speed Demon	50p
[]	No Continues Used	25p

ACHIEVEMENT!

+25 pts Perfect Run



What is MiSTer Monitor

MiSTer Monitor turns an ESP32-based touchscreen into a companion display for your MiSTer: the moment you load a game, the screen shows its box art, a “Now Playing” panel with related info (year, dev, publisher, genre, players, rating and synopsis) of the active game, your **RetroAchievements** progress, and live system stats. Everything is fetched on demand, and when the MiSTer is switched off the screen dims to a standby clock.

Two pieces work together: a tiny **server** on the MiSTer that watches what you play, and the **firmware** on the display that renders it. You will install both.

You will need

- A **MiSTer** connected to your home network.
- A supported display: **M5Stack Tab5** (5"), **Guitiion JC8012P4A1C** (10.1"), or a **Cheap Yellow Display** (2.8" ILI9341/ST7789, or 3.5" capacitive/resistive).
- A **microSD card** for the display.
- A **USB data cable** and a desktop computer with **Chrome or Edge** (only for the one-time flash).
- A free **ScreenScraper** account — created in step 3.
- Optional: a free **RetroAchievements** account — step 5.

1

Flash the display

- Connect the display to your computer with the USB cable.
- Open the flasher page in **Chrome or Edge** (Firefox and Safari don't support Web Serial):

```
https://chipster6502.github.io/MiSTer\_monitor/flasher/
```

- Click **Connect** next to your board, pick the serial port in the browser dialog, and wait for the confirmation.
- Not sure which CYD variant you have? The page itself explains how to tell them apart.

2

Prepare the display's microSD card

The repository ships a ready-made card layout under **SD_card_content/**. Pick the subfolder matching your board, copy its contents to the **root** of the microSD card, then open **config.ini** in any text editor and fill in your network — **without quotes** around the values:

```
config.ini — on the display's microSD card

[wifi]

ssid=YOUR_WIFI_NAME

password=YOUR_WIFI_PASSWORD
```

That is all the display needs to find the MiSTer: it discovers it automatically on the network at boot.

This first edit has to happen on a computer, because the display needs the WiFi details before it can be reached over the network. From then on you can edit **config.ini** from a browser instead — see step 6.

NOTE With a single MiSTer, leave **[mister] ip=** blank. With several MiSTers on the network, set it to the address of the one this display should follow — it will never adopt another. Set it too if your router blocks UDP broadcast, which is rare in home networks.

IMPORTANT Guition 10.1" only. Guition ships this board with two different panels. If the screen shows horizontal colour bands instead of the interface, yours is the newer one — batch 2624 onward, the figure in parentheses after the SKU on the back sticker — and needs `pane_l_rev=v2` in the **[ui]** section. Keep `c6_firmware.bin` in the root of the card too: if the board's WiFi chip carries firmware too old to connect, the display updates it from that file at boot, by itself.

3 Create a free ScreenScraper account

- Register at screenscraper.fr — free, instant, no approval needed.
- Add your username and password to the same **config.ini**:

```
config.ini – same file, next section  
[screenscraper]  
ss_user=YOUR_SS_USERNAME  
ss_pass=YOUR_SS_PASSWORD
```

The app brings its own developer credentials, so a plain member account is enough. Artwork is downloaded the first time each game appears and cached on the card, so it costs quota once and loads instantly forever after.

4 Install the server on the MiSTer

One toggle in Update All or MiSTer Companion — it updates itself from then on

Pick whichever updater you already use. Both install the same files and keep them current from then on.

- **Update All** — run it from the Scripts menu and press **UP** during the countdown to open the settings. Go to **Tools & Scripts** and enable **MiSTer Monitor**, then save and let the update finish. (Requires Update All 2.10 or newer.)
- **MiSTer Companion** — open **Install Center**, find **MiSTer Monitor** and install it.

IMPORTANT Then run **MiSTer_Monitor** once from the **Scripts** menu. Downloading the files is not enough: this run enables auto-start on boot, sets `log_file_entry=1` in **MiSTer.ini** — which is what lets the server see the loaded game, so without it no artwork ever appears — and starts the server. It is safe to run again at any time, and doing so after an update restarts the server on the new version.

- Insert the card in your display and power it.
- Load any game. Within a few seconds the display shows its artwork.

TIP While you are in the Update All settings, look under **Extra Content** → **Game Artwork DBs**. The **artwork packs** install box art for thousands of games straight onto the MiSTer, so covered games appear instantly without a ScreenScraper lookup. They are optional — everything works without them, and ScreenScraper still fills in whatever a pack does not cover.

NOTE Running the **Downloader** on its own, without Update All? A drop-in database file does the same job — see [installation.md](#). Use one route or the other, not both.

IMPORTANT **Console Mode** (Taki Udon's frontend) replaces **MiSTer.ini** with its own copy, which turns game detection back off. If you install or repair it, run **MiSTer_Monitor** once more afterwards and everything returns to normal.

To pause the monitor, run **MiSTer_Monitor_uninstall** from the Scripts menu; run **MiSTer_Monitor** again to re-enable it.

5

RetroAchievements (optional)

Your progress and live unlock popups on the display

This part lives **on the MiSTer**, not on the display's card. The first time the server runs it drops a ready-to-edit file in place — you only fill in two lines:

```
on the MiSTer — created automatically on first start
/media/fat/Scripts/.config/mister_monitor/ra_credentials.ini

[retroachievements]
username=YourRAUsername
api_key=YourWebAPIKey
```

Your **Web API key** is at retroachievements.org → *Settings* → *Applications*. Load a game with a published set and the RetroAchievements page comes alive: progress bar, points, and the full trophy list — tap any row for its description.

Your setup	What you get
Credentials only stock MiSTer	The full page in view-only mode: the game's set, your cloud progress and every trophy — but play is not recorded.
odelot/Main_MiSTer fork RA_cores	Achievements are earned while you play ; a READY banner confirms it on each matched game, and unlocks pop within seconds.
Fork + debug=1 retroachievements.cfg	Popups become instant (with title and description), and CD systems — PlayStation, Saturn, Mega CD — resolve too.

IMPORTANT Each tier is optional and falls back gracefully to the one below. Without the credentials file, everything else in this guide works exactly the same.

Earning achievements on the MiSTer

Recording achievements needs odelot's RetroAchievements build of the MiSTer main binary, plus his modified core for each system. Two maintained routes install it for you, both keeping your stock cores intact:

- **Update All** — the RetroAchievements Cores database, maintained by odelot himself, is now built in. Run **Update All**, enable it in the settings screen, and it walks you through the `retroachievements.cfg` setup and the `MiSTer.ini` entries it needs.
- **MiSTer Companion** — install the **RetroAchievements Cores** entry from its **Install Center**. (mistercompanion.org)

Either route leaves a `retroachievements.cfg` on the MiSTer holding your RA **username and password**. That file belongs to odelot's build and is separate from the `ra_credentials.ini` above, which is this project's and takes an API key instead — you will end up with both, and that is expected.

```
two different files, both needed for the full experience

/media/fat/retroachievements.cfg      odelot's build (user + password)
/media/fat/Scripts/.config/mister_monitor/ra_credentials.ini
                                     this project   (user + API key)
```

IMPORTANT Once the RA cores are installed an **RA_Cores** entry appears in the MiSTer OSD. Achievements are only active for cores launched from there — opening the same system from its usual menu entry runs the stock core and records nothing.

TIP Add `debug=1` to `retroachievements.cfg` for sub-second unlock popups. Achievements only work on the systems odelot has published cores for — [his repository](#) lists the current set.

6

The web interface

Edit settings and manage the display's card from any browser

Once the display is on your network it runs a small web interface of its own. Point a browser at **the display's own IP address** on port 8080 — not the MiSTer's. The display shows its address on the boot screen once it connects, and on the **Network** page as **Monitor IP**, right below the MiSTer's.

```
edit config.ini
http://<display-ip>:8080/config
```

The page opens the card's **config.ini** in a text editor, exactly as it is written, comments and all. Saving writes it back to the microSD and keeps the previous version as **config.ini.bak** on the same card. Settings are read once at startup, so the page offers a **Reboot** button to apply them — the display restarts in a couple of seconds.

```
browse the microSD card
http://<display-ip>:8080/files
```

The same interface lists the card's contents: open folders, download a file to your computer, upload new ones, create folders, and delete what you no longer need. The most common use is artwork — delete the image for one game and it will be fetched again next time you load it, or upload your own to replace it.

NOTE Artwork you upload must be **baseline** JPEG. Progressive JPEGs are rejected with a message, because the display's decoder cannot read them. Most image editors offer the choice when exporting. Deleting covers files and empty folders; to remove a folder with contents, empty it first.

The interface has no password by default, which is fine on a home network. To lock it, set a password in the **[ui]** section of config.ini — the browser will then ask for it, with the username **admin**. Setting **web_config=false** disables the whole web interface.

```
config.ini - optional
[ui]
web_config=true
web_password=
```

The 2.8" boards, the Tab5 and the Guition also serve a screenshot of what is on screen at **http://<display-ip>:8080/**. The 3.5" boards do not: their panel cannot be read back.



You're done — a quick check

Working as intended looks like this

- Boot: the display connects to WiFi and finds the MiSTer by itself.
- Load a game: box art appears within seconds; the Game Info panel fills in year, developer and synopsis.
- RetroAchievements page: progress and trophies for the running game (view-only unless you installed the fork and open a RA enabled core).
- System pages: live CPU, memory, storage and network stats.
- Switch the MiSTer off: after three minutes the display dims to its standby screen, and it wakes by itself when the MiSTer comes back.
- Web interface: **http://<display-ip>:8080/config** opens the settings editor from any browser on your network.



Everything config.ini can do

Every option, grouped by what you want to achieve — all of it optional

Steps 2 and 3 filled in the only values the display really needs. Everything else in **config.ini** already has a sensible default, and this section is the map of what you can change. The file itself carries a comment above every key, and **configuration.md** goes into more detail.

- Edit it from a browser at **http://<display-ip>:8080/config** (step 6). Settings are read once at startup, so press **Reboot** on that page to apply a change.
- A missing key keeps its default, so an older config.ini keeps working after an update. Newer options are in the config.ini under **SD_card_content/** for your board — copy their lines across.
- Section names such as **[ui]** only organise the file; keys are found by name.

Network and accounts

Key	Default	What it does
ssid password	—	Your WiFi network, without quotes.
ip	blank	Blank: the display finds the MiSTer by itself. Set: it follows that MiSTer and no other — see step 2.
ss_user ss_pass	—	Your free ScreenScraper member account.
region	wor	Artwork region tried first: wor , us , eu or jp . The others follow in a fixed order.
timeout retries use_https	30000 2 false	ScreenScraper connection: request timeout in ms, retries when the service is overloaded, and HTTPS — enable that one only if plain HTTP stops working.

Which artwork is downloaded

Four lists decide which image types are requested from ScreenScraper, each tried left to right until one exists. Reorder them to taste, or remove a type to skip it.

Key	Used for
game_media_order	Console and computer games. Box art first.
arcade_media_order	Arcade games. Fan art and marquees first — most have no box.
core_media_order	The system itself (Mega Drive, Amiga...). Logo wheels first.
arcade_subsystem_media_order	Arcade platforms (CPS1, Sega Classics...). Logo wheels first.

the image types you can list

```
for games    box3d box2d fanart marquee screenshot titlescreen mix1 mix2
for systems  screenmarquee background photo illustration
for both     wheel-steel wheel-carbon wheel
```

Key	Default	What it does
<code>auto_download</code>	<code>true</code>	Fetch missing artwork from ScreenScraper.
<code>force_core_redownload</code> <code>force_game_redownload</code>	<code>false</code> <code>false</code>	Fetch again even when the image is already on the card. Set for one boot, then back to false .
<code>max_image_size</code> <code>download_timeout</code>	500000 30000	Largest image accepted, in bytes, and the download timeout in ms.
<code>base_path</code> <code>default_image</code> <code>alphabetical_folders</code>	/cores /cores/menu.jpg <code>true</code>	Where images live on the card, the default image, and whether they are sorted into lettered folders. Rarely worth changing.

What the image screen shows

Key	Default	What it does
<code>image_mode</code>	<code>rotate</code>	rotate alternates the game's artwork and the system's; game and system stay on one and never switch.
<code>core_image_timeout</code> <code>system_image_timeout</code>	30000 0	How long each slide stays up, in ms. The second gives the system slide its own time; 0 means the same as the first.
<code>info_in_rotation</code>	<code>false</code>	Adds the GAME INFO panel to the rotation as a third slide.
<code>image_upscale</code> <code>image_upscale_max</code>	<code>false</code> 2.5	Grow artwork that is smaller than the display area until it fills it, up to that multiplier. Most visible on the Tab5 and the Guition.
<code>kiosk_mode</code> <code>kiosk_hide_delay_ms</code>	<code>false</code> 5000	Give the whole panel to the artwork and hide the footer. A tap brings the footer up for that many ms; a second tap works as usual.

NOTE Kiosk mode asks ScreenScraper for taller images, so artwork already on the card shows a black band above and below until it is fetched again. Set both `force_..._redownload` keys to **true** for one boot, or delete the images from the web interface.

The Game Info panel

Key	Default	What it does
<code>info_lang</code>	<code>en</code>	Language of the synopsis and genre: en es pt fr de it . Falls back to English.
<code>info_scroll_auto</code> <code>info_scroll_step_ms</code>	<code>true</code> 2000	Scroll the synopsis by itself, and how fast, in ms per line — higher is slower.
<code>info_synopsis_max</code>	2000	Longest synopsis kept per game, in characters. A memory limit; rarely needs changing.

Standby and clock

With the MiSTer switched off there is nothing to show, so the display dims to a standby screen. It wakes by itself when the MiSTer answers again or the core or game changes, and at a touch.

Key	Default	What it does
<code>standby_screen</code>	<code>clock</code>	clock : a large clock, the date, whether the MiSTer is online and what it is running. minimal : the MiSTer logo and a small state dot. The clock needs a timezone ; until it has one, minimal is shown.
<code>standby_when_offline</code> <code>standby_offline_min</code>	<code>true</code> <code>3</code>	Go to standby once the MiSTer has been unreachable for that many minutes. false turns it off.
<code>standby_idle_min</code>	<code>0</code>	Also go to standby after this many minutes with no core change, game change, achievement or touch — even with the MiSTer running. 0 = never.
<code>standby_brightness</code>	<code>10</code>	Backlight level in standby, 0–255. 0 switches it off.
<code>standby_dim</code>	<code>100</code>	Darkens what the standby screen draws, as a percentage. For Tab5 units whose backlight only switches on and off: try 30. Leave at 100 elsewhere.
<code>timezone</code>	<code>blank</code>	Where you are — a name from the list below, or a POSIX TZ string. Blank: no clock anywhere.
<code>ntp_server</code> <code>clock_24h</code>	<code>pool.ntp.org</code> <code>true</code>	The time server, and 24-hour or AM/PM time.

```
timezone names — each covers every country that shares its time
uk  portugal  iceland  spain  nigeria  greece  southafrica  turkey
dubai  india  thailand  china  japan  sydney  newzealand
argentina  venezuela  colombia  mexico
useastern  uscentral  usmountain  uspacific

[ui]
timezone=spain
```

TIP **spain** also covers France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Poland and Sweden; **uk** covers Ireland; **japan** covers South Korea. The full list of countries is in config.ini, above the key. Daylight saving changes are handled.

Screen, sound and web interface

Key	Default	What it does
<code>flip_display</code>	false	Turn the picture 180°, touch included, for cases that hold the board upside down.
<code>scroll_speed_ms</code> <code>scroll_pause_start_ms</code> <code>scroll_pause_end_ms</code>	300 2000 3000	Scrolling of long names in the footer: ms per step — lower is faster — and the pauses before it starts and before it resets.
<code>sound</code> <code>sound_volume</code>	true 128	Tab5 only. Silence the boot jingle and touch beeps, or set the volume, 0–255.
<code>panel_rev</code>	v1	Guition only. v2 for units from batch 2624 onward — see step 2.
<code>web_config</code> <code>web_password</code>	true blank	Switch the web interface off, or protect it with a password (username admin) — see step 6.
<code>debug</code>	false	Verbose messages on the serial port, for troubleshooting.

links

Project github.com/chipster6502/MiSTer_monitor
Docs [installation.md](#) [configuration.md](#)
Flasher chipster6502.github.io/MiSTer_monitor/flasher/
RetroAchiev. retroachievements.org
RA fork github.com/odelot/Main_MiSTer
Update All github.com/theypsilon/Update_All_MiSTer
Companion mistercompanion.org
Display UI <http://<display-ip>:8080/config>
Server page <http://<mister-ip>:8081/>

MiSTer Monitor is free software — firmware under GPL-3.0, server under AGPL-3.0. Found a rough edge in this guide? Open an issue; it helps the next person.